

EC switches to damage control mode after facing flak over SIR

Poll body announces 'special drive' for enrolment of those left out during the SIR; additional declaration with Form 6 only for the SIR period, it says; decisions, coming days after reports of rift within EC, have 'approval of full commission', it notes

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission (EC) on Saturday announced a slew of measures addressing concerns over the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls across the country, including stopping physical hearings for unmapped voters or those with logical discrepancies in their enumeration forms.

It said that the declaration accompanying Form 6 (used for fresh voter registration) is mandatory only during the current SIR process. This in effect means that new voters who seek inclusion in electoral rolls after the ongoing SIR need not submit any such declaration.

The Election Commis-

Revised process

The EC, which held a meeting on Saturday, said that any person whose name has got left out during SIR or thereafter may apply to the ERO concerned for inclusion in the electoral rolls

KEY DECISIONS

- Election officers to immediately launch a special drive for enrolment of electors left out of rolls
- Declaration attached to Form 6 to be used only for SIR

- BLOs to visit houses of voters issued notice under SIR
- A panel with an independent expert from IIT/IIT to review ECINet platform
- Claims and objections period for SIR in Delhi and Maharashtra extended



CEC Gyanesh Kumar with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi during a meeting in New Delhi on Saturday. ANI

sion also said that any person whose name has got left out during SIR or thereafter, and any person including young/ first-time voters, may apply to the electoral registration officer (ERO) concerned, for inclusion of their names in the electoral rolls.

A special drive will im-

mediately be launched for their enrolment, it said in a press note.

The SIR process has already been completed in 20 States and Union Territories.

The fresh initiatives of the poll body came after a meeting of the full bench of the commission on Sa-

turday afternoon and days after reports emerged of a rift within the Election Commissioners over these and other issues in the SIR process as well as the internal working of the EC.

'Complete approval'
The Election Commission's press note was pertinently

Congress urges top court to hold CEC accountable

NEW DELHI

The Congress on Saturday urged the Supreme Court to take *suo motu* cognisance of what it described as "illegal and unconstitutional" changes to the voter enrolment process under CEC Gyanesh Kumar while holding him accountable for the changes. » **PAGE 7**

accompanied by a photograph of all the three Election Commissioners and mentioned that it "has the approval of the full commission".

MORE TIME FOR CLAIMS
» **PAGE 7**
DISSENT IN THE COMMISSION
» **PAGE 13**

Jaishankar lashes out at Sharif in UN speech

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Delivering India's National Statement at the UN General Assembly, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Saturday said the country will exercise its right to defend itself against terrorism while focusing on the impact of conflicts on the Global South.

In a response to Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's speech a day before, where he had criticised India for launching Operation Sindoor last year, Mr. Jaishankar said that there could be "no dilution" of the world's zero-tolerance approach to terrorism. "Yesterday, a serial practitioner of terrorism misrepresented facts before this Assembly. Arguments were invoked to normalise terrorism and claim immunity from its consequences," Mr. Jaishankar said, attacking Mr. Sharif's speech, in which he had called Kashmir the "jugu-



S. Jaishankar

lar vein" of Pakistan and accused India of human rights violations in the region. Mr. Sharif had also claimed that the BJP government in India unleashed a "reign of terror" against minorities in the country.

"Our right to defend ourselves against terrorism will be exercised," Mr. Jaishankar said, adding that governments indulging in state-sponsored terrorism with a "cross-border purpose" must be held to account.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 7**

Jaishankar lashes out at Sharif in UN speech

Earlier in the day, Indian and Pakistani diplomats also exchanged sharp words as India exercised its right to reply to the Pakistan PM's speech.

He also made a pitch for reformed multilateralism, a reference to expanding the UN Security Council to become more representative.

SC had warned against leaving EC's powers in the hands of one person

A multi-member EC has to conduct its work in cooperation, appreciating and respecting each other's points of view, the court had said.

Personal law has no immunity from POCSO Act: HC

The Delhi High Court has held that a marriage recognised under Muslim personal law cannot confer immunity from prosecution under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act when the wife is below 18 at the time of sexual intercourse.

Justice Sanjeev Narula, in a judgment delivered on Wednesday, dismissed a petition seeking quashing of a First Information Report registered against a man for rape under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the POCSO Act, holding that “personal law may determine whether a marriage has been contracted”, but cannot create an exception to a criminal law where Parliament has provided none.

“A marriage may have consequences for status, maintenance, legitimacy, residence and rights between the parties. It does not necessarily immunise

conduct that a secular penal statute independently prohibits," the judge said.

The case concerned a woman who was 16 years and three months old when she married the petitioner, then nearly 28, on December 20, 2024. She became pregnant, and her age came to light when she visited a government hospital during the pregnancy.

The woman consistently told the authorities that she had married voluntarily with the consent of both families and had not been subjected to force or coercion. She also supported the petitioner's bail plea.

The petitioners argued that under Muslim personal law, a Muslim girl who had attained puberty was competent to marry and that the subsequent sexual relationship therefore could not attract criminal liability. The court rejected the contention, holding that the POCSO Act fixes 18 as the age below which consent to sexual activity has no legal efficacy.

SC judge advises wider use of mediation in family feuds

GUWAHATI

Supreme Court judge Justice B.V. Nagarathna on Saturday called for greater reliance on alternative dispute resolution in family litigation, arguing that mediation and conciliation could deliver faster, less adversarial outcomes than prolonged court battles.

Justice Nagarathna was delivering the inaugural address on 'ADR (alternative dispute resolution) versus Adjudication in Family Disputes: Challenges and Way Forward' at the Eastern Zone Regional Conference of the Committee for Family Court Matters, Supreme Court of India, in association with the Gauhati High Court, in Guwahati. She told delegates that alternative dispute resolution was never intended to compete with the courts but to complement them, offering speed, privacy, and confidentiality.



Justice B.V. Nagarathna

that conventional litigation often cannot.

Justice Nagarathna, who chairs the top court's Committee for Family Court Matters, noted that many years pass between filing pleadings and a final judgment. By then, "any semblance of subsisting familial bond" is often lost.

Such delay, she warned, tends to deepen existing inequalities within families, making reducing the backlog through alternative dispute resolution a pressing priority.

Citing data from the Department of Justice, she said the country had 822 functioning family courts as of October 2024. Among the eastern States, Bihar topped the list with 70,365 pending cases, followed by Odisha (36,792), Jharkhand (15,376), Assam (7,399), and Tripura (4,010).

Justice Nagarathna underlined a series of proposals across many key areas. On cases involving overlapping issues of domestic violence and elder welfare, she recommended “consolidated referral”, under which related proceedings arising from a single household could be directed to one mediator with unified judicial oversight.

On matrimonial disputes, she said pre-litigation mediation should be promoted under Section 5 of the Mediation Act, and conciliation should be scheduled at the first hearing of contested divorce and restitution petitions.

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Non-profits lag on technological maturity in India, a new report based on a survey of 500 organisations in the sector said.

Even as white collar organisations employing college-educated workers experiment heavily with AI and integrate it into their workflows, non-profits did not score even 50% on digital maturity, even as they showed some interest in using large language models (LLMs) to help with reports and marketing. Delhi-based Digital for Nonprofits (D4NP) said in its State of Nonprofits Digitization Report 2026.

‘Always the last’

In any industry, D4NP founder and former Google executive Abhinav Chetan said, “non-profits are always the last, no matter which technological trend you pick ... They’re still experimenting. They’re still at level one, by the way – they’re only using it for conversations. They’re not really using it for complicated workflows.”

While AI systems have made it far easier for organisations to do routine work faster, Mr. Chetan said that many were lagging behind on even the earlier digitisation wave.

One example the report cited was most organisations not taking advantage of monthly \$10,000 ad grants. That came out to millions of dollars of free advertising money simply lying unused.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Centre has notified Deendayal (Kandla), Jawaharlal Nehru (Nhava Sheva), Paradip and Mundra ports as mega ports under the Indian Ports Act, 2025.

The notification was issued by the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways on September 25, 2026, and came into force on its publication in the Gazette of India.

Deendayal, Jawaharlal

Nehru and Paradip are major ports. Mundra, operated by Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone, is a port other than a major port. The major ports were notified under Section 73 (2) of the Act and Mundra under Section 73(3).

The notification states that the four ports satisfy the criteria for classification as a mega port.

These criteria were notified on July 30, 2026 in consultation with State governments.

SCIENCE

Chemists report ‘milder’ way to swap carbon for nitrogen atoms

Vasudevan Mukunth

When working with drug candidates, chemists sometimes like to replace a carbon atom in a ring of atoms with a nitrogen atom. This is because the switch can significantly alter the molecule's properties, including how well it dissolves or how it interacts with biological targets in the body. But achieving it has been quite difficult, requiring chemical reactions with powerful

oxidants, say, that can damage other parts of the molecule.

A new study in *Science* offers a breakthrough: researchers from the University of Chicago have reported a reaction to replace carbon with nitrogen in types of molecules often encountered in medical research and industry, in “mild conditions”.

Chemists had previously banked on a highly reactive intermediate compound called a nitrene to

help push a nitrogen atom into a ring. The problem is nitrenes can have different electronic states, one of which – called the triplet state – doesn’t perform the desired reaction. But in the new work, the team set up a series of reactions that used the triplet nitrene state to temporarily open the ring, rearrange the atoms’ positions, and close it such that a nitrogen occurred where a carbon had been. When they tested their technique on a type

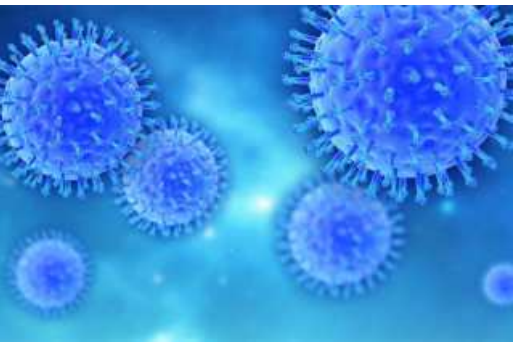
of indole that had resisted existing methods, the researchers found the nitrogen-containing version in 73% of the reaction’s yield. After also trying it on other molecules, the team turned to biologically active molecules, which can be quite complex. The team modified one of the cancer-fighting compounds called the Vinca alkaloids to produce a version with nitrogen, which they found had better metabolic properties and less

inhibition of the hERG potassium channel.

Finally, the team was also able to produce nitrogen-containing versions of two natural compounds: yohimbine, a veterinary drug, and catharanthine, one of the precursors of the chemotherapy drug vinblastine. This is valuable because synthesising them with nitrogen at the outset can change the molecules’ reactivity, putting paid to established synthetic routes. That said, the

method is not universal, as the authors have acknowledged, and includes toxic compounds called aryl azides among the starting materials. Even so, as they wrote in their paper, “The mild reaction conditions and broad skeletal diversity... lend an unexpected degree of generality to this method”, and they “anticipate that this addition to the toolkit for C-to-N transmutation will find promising applications in medicinal chemistry.”

SNAPSHOTS



PFOS disrupts immune system’s antiviral action

PFOS, a widespread industrial ‘forever chemical’, weakens the body’s ability to fight viral infections, a study has found. Researchers found that it binds to an immune protein called IRF3, which keeps it from triggering the release of interferons, our immune system’s top antiviral defence. As a result, viruses can multiply faster. Tests in human cells and mice showed that everyday levels of PFOS exposure led to more severe infections from viruses like influenza and hepatitis B.



IIT-Madras tool bridges quake science and dam safety

An IIT-Madras team evaluated 6,545 dams under India’s National Dam Safety Authority and found standard seismic zone maps misjudge earthquake risks. For Himalayan ‘megadams’ like Tehri and Bhakra, site-specific modelling revealed projected ground accelerations were too conservative. The team achieved this using a combination of a tool it built to perform “probabilistic seismic hazard analysis”, a catalogue of 68,000+ earthquakes from 2,600 BC to 2019, and maps of India’s major faultlines.



Eukaryote sets record for warmest reproduction

Scientists have found a new species of amoeba, *Incandiamoeba cascadenis*, in hot springs in California that has set a record for the upper temperature limit of eukaryotic life. Scientists previously thought these lifeforms couldn’t reproduce above 60° C. However, *I. cascadenis* replicates at 63° C. It activates genes to repair DNA and cell membranes. Its proteins’ chemical properties are such that they don’t clump together, a trick heat-loving bacteria use as well.

How wealth shapes our view of artificial intelligence



John Xavier

There’s a common assumption that anxiety about artificial intelligence is universal – that everyone, everywhere, is bracing for the same disruption. But, a new Pew Research Centre Survey of over 42,000 adults across 37 countries suggests otherwise.

The survey’s data points out that worry about AI tracks closely with wealth. The richer the country, the more its people fear AI will take their jobs, widen inequality, and disrupt daily life. The poorer the country, the less its citizens fear AI as they simply haven’t formed an opinion on it yet.

Per capita income, it turns out, may be the single best predictor of how a population feels about AI.

The researchers split 36 core countries into 18 “high-income” and 18 “middle-income” nations, using World Bank’s classifications built on gross national income per capita. The gap between the two groups shows up in nearly every question that was part of the survey.

A median of 55% of adults in high-income countries said AI will lead to fewer jobs in their country over the next decades. In middle-income countries, that figure drops nearly 20 points lower to 36%. People in poorer countries aren’t necessarily more hopeful; they’re more uncertain.

Roughly a third of the adults in middle-income nations said they simply don’t know how AI will affect jobs, compared with about a fifth in wealthy ones.

The same pattern holds for inequality. A median of 35% of adults in high-income countries believe AI



Divergence in attitudes of people seems to be a function of the level of awareness of new technologies. GETTY IMAGES

will widen the gap between rich and poor, versus 22% in middle-income countries.

In general, 40% of the respondents in the wealthy nations said they were more concerned than excited about AI’s growing presence in their daily lives, compared with 31% in middle-income nations.

When the researchers plotted individual countries against their GDP per capita, the correlation between GDP per capita and the belief that AI cost jobs was strong. On AI aware-

ness – the share of people who said they’ve heard or read ‘a lot’ about AI – the connection was even stronger.

Respondents in two Asian nations capture this divide. In Singapore, for instance, where GDP per capita is close to \$100,000, 53% of its adults said they’ve heard or read ‘a lot’ about AI. In Bangladesh, where GDP per capita is about \$2,600, just 4% of its adults reported the same level of awareness.

Loss of job loss follows the same pattern as rough-

ly seven in ten or more adults in Australia, South Korea and the U.S. expect AI to shrink the job market over the next two decades. But in Kenya, Nigeria and the Philippines, that expectation is far less common as they are yet to form a strong view on the technology.

Nearly half of Americans said the technology will widen the gap between rich and poor. In India, however, which is classified as a middle-income country, only 13% said the same.

This divergence in attitudes of people in high-income and middle-income economies seems to be a function of the level of awareness of new technologies.

People in advanced economies are far more likely to have encountered AI tools directly that have visibly threatened their job prospects.

In middle-income nations, however, where in-

formal labour and manual work still make up a large share of employment, AI’s impact can feel more abstract.

Pew Research Centre found that in many middle-income countries, it’s the wealthier and more educated people within that country who are most likely to say AI will cost jobs or deepen inequality.

Much of the gap traces back to the same driver: people with less income and less formal education are simply more likely to say they’re unsure of this technology. Uncertainty fills the space where worry would otherwise occupy.

The implication of this survey is double-edged for citizens and governments. Concern is often what drives demand for regulation and worker protections. That means the countries best positioned to frame laws around AI’s disruptions may be exactly the ones already feeling the most anxious about it.

